The Indie Filmmaker

Guneet Monga, *40*
Film producer



MILIND SHELTE

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Gave India its first Oscar-winning film with the documentary short, *The Elephant Whisperers*

"YOU COME INTO THIS LIFE with breath and no name and you leave with name and no breath." Guneet Monga holds these words by Swami Gaur Gopal Das very close to her heart. "Our taste is what defines us, and my taste is for good storytelling," she says. Guneet wants to do the kind of work that makes her proud even decades later, and with a host of critically-acclaimed titles to her name today, she seems to have fulfilled that quest: *Gangs of Wasseypur* I & II (2012), *The Lunchbox*, *Shahid* (2013), *Masaan* (2015), *Soorarai Pottru* (2019), *Pagglait* (2021) and *The Elephant Whisperers* (2022), which became India's first Oscar-winning film in the documentary short category. Her knack of getting funding and putting Indian films on the world map through international festivals has earned Guneet the title of the 'Queen of Indie Cinema'.

Guneet has come a long way since her days as a production coordinator. She started with Anurag Kashyap Films (2009-13), where she raised money for the first features of filmmakers like Vasan Bala (*Peddlers*) and Neeraj Ghaywan (*Masaan*). Later, she turned her attention to her own banner, Sikhya Entertainment, under which she produced *Dasvidaniya* (2008). She was just 25 back then.

Over the past few years, her banner has been focusing on women-led filmmakers. The MeToo movement was a moment of reckoning. "I realised with whatever access I have, I want to put more women through the door." And thus came projects with Sudha Kongara (*Soorarai Pottru*), Rayka Zehtabchi (*Period. End of Sentence*) and Kartiki Gonsalves (*The Elephant Whisperers*).

Guneet says she is still just starting off. There are ongoing deals for her next co-production, *Kill*. "I still don't have a Rs 100 crore box-office film. Rs 500 crore will happen. And $2 billion has to happen.... I want to make India's *Brown Panther*. I want to put India on the map in the best way." In Guneet, we believe. ■

–Suhani Singh

MY BEST ADVICE

"Honesty goes a long way and people notice it. Also, celebrate the no's because the yes is coming"

↘ ROLE MODEL Filmmaker Ava DuVernay. "She told me once to 'just break open the door'"

↘ STARTING YOUNG At 21, Monga convinced her neighbour, who wanted to invest his money—Rs 50 lakh—in making "cute videos of kids" to instead produce her first feature, *Say Salaam India* (2007)